

who have never experienced it. It was a physical sensation, perhaps a mixture of joy, pride, and terror.

And I felt vindicated? How?

During the one or two years after my arrival at Wharton, I had developed a precise but strange specialty: betting on rare and unexpected events, those that were on the *Platonic fold*, and considered “inconceivable” by the Platonic “experts.” Recall that the Platonic fold is where our representation of reality ceases to apply—but we do not know it.

For I was early to embrace, as a day job, the profession of “quantitative finance.” I became a “quant” and trader at the same time—a quant is a brand of industrial scientist who applies mathematical models of uncertainty to financial (or socioeconomic) data and complex financial instruments. Except that I was a quant exactly in reverse: I studied the flaws and the limits of these models, looking for the *Platonic fold* where they break down. Also I engaged in speculative trading, not “just tawk,” which was rare for quants since they were prevented from “taking risks,” their role being confined to analysis, not decision making. I was convinced that I was totally incompetent in predicting market prices—but that others were generally incompetent also but did not know it, or did not know that they were taking massive risks. Most traders were just “picking pennies in front of a streamroller,” exposing themselves to the high-impact rare event yet sleeping like babies, unaware of it. Mine was the only job you could do if you thought of yourself as risk-hating, risk-aware, and highly ignorant.

Also, the technical baggage that comes with being a quant (a mixture of applied mathematics, engineering, and statistics), in addition to the immersion in practice, turned out to be very useful for someone wanting to be a philosopher.* First, when you spend a couple of decades doing mass-scale empirical work with data and taking risks based on such studies, you can easily spot elements in the texture of the world that the Platonified “thinker” is too brainwashed, or threatened, to see. Second, it allowed me to become formal and systematic in my thinking instead of wallowing in the anecdotal. Finally, both the philosophy of history and epistemology (the philosophy of knowledge) seemed inseparable from the empirical study of times series data, which is a succession of numbers in time, a sort of historical document containing numbers instead of words. And numbers are easy to process on computers. Studying historical data makes you conscious that history runs forward, not backward, and that it is messier than narrated accounts. Epistemology, the philosophy of history, and statistics aim at understanding truths, investigating the mechanisms that generate them, and separating regularity from the coincidental in historical matters. They all address the